bridge collapse of 2022 being the most prominent. Fuelling public anger is the feeling that justice has not been served—all the older cases are still in court, most of the accused are out on bail and no action has been taken against the officials responsible either (see *No Lessons Learnt*). This time, four of the seven people who were operating the game zone have been arrested and the de rigueur special investigation team (SIT) has been formed to look into the incident. The public clamour has also led to the suspension of seven mid- and low-level officials for 'dereliction of duty'.

But it was not enough to satisfy the public or the court, which categorically pointed out how senior officials had not been taken to task. Following the HC's censure, Rajkot police commissioner Raju Bhargava, DCP Zone 2 Sudhirkumar Desai, ACP Vidhi Chaudhary and Rajkot municipal commissioner Anand Patel were shunted out. Indeed, by that time, the administration had nowhere to hide, for a March 2022 social media post by 'trp_games_food_entertainment' had surfaced showing Rajkot collector Arun Mahesh Babu, municipal commissioner Amit Arora and DCP Zone 1 Pravin Meena posing with the game zone's representatives.

The HC took cognisance of this as well, and asked, "Who are these people? Did they go there to play?" It also pointed out that the RMC chief had attended the inauguration of the illegal gaming zone. "For three years, you did not inquire into it. The activity was merrily going on without permission in front of the corporation," Justice Vaishnav remarked. He also said that all the municipal commissioners who served between June 2021 (when go-karting operations first started at the zone) and now should be held accountable for the tragedy.

It has also emerged that the gaming zone had never applied for the mandatory fire NOC (no-objection certificate). The Rajkot police had issued it a 'booking licence' allowing commercial operations, but the city's fire and emergency services chief I.V. Kher said the city police never consulted them. The licence was first granted in 2023 and renewed this January. Some 2,000 litres of diesel, 1,500 litres of petrol and many LPG cylinders were stored at the facility. The incident has now raised questions about the procurement and storage norms for the fuels.

The root of the problem is the policy on such 'recreational facilities'. Dozens of similar gaming zones operate illegally because of the loopholes in the Comprehensive General Development Control Regulations (CGDCR) issued in 2014. To sidestep the clearances, the businesses operate out of temporary structures. Those operating inside malls rely on the mall's fire safety structure.

Following the incident, all 101 gaming arcades across the state were shut down till inspection and certification for fire safety and compliance with SOPs. But then, the state government's kneejerk reaction has also come in for flak. Congress spokesperson Manish Doshi says, "After the fire at the illegal tuition centre in Surat in 2019 [where 22 children lost their lives], all coaching classes across the state were shut down for a fortnight. After the Harni boat accident, all boating facilities were shut down, and after the Morbi bridge incident, all pedestrian bridges.... But then what? They opened again, with or without inspection." Lives are lost, and life goes on. ■

NO LESSONS LEARNT

↘ May 2019, Surat

22 children die due to fire in an illegal coaching class operating from the terrace of Takshashila Building

Accused: 13, including 8 government officials

Status: 12 accused out on bail. Three suspended officers reinstated in 2021

↘ July 2019, Ahmedabad

Two die, 27 seriously hurt as amusement park ride snaps in Kankaria

Accused: Six, including officials and proprietor of Superstar Amusement Pvt Ltd, which was blacklisted by the municipal corporation

Status: Contractor has resumed operations

↘ Oct. 2022, Morbi

Footbridge over Machchhu river falls, killing 135

Accused: 10, including ticketing officials, guards and proprietor Jaysukh Patel. No state official charged

Status: Nine accused, including Patel, out on bail

↘ Jan. 2024, Vadodara

14, including 12 schoolkids, die as overloaded boat capsizes on Harni lake

Accused: 20, no state official charged

Status: 17 accused out on bail



PTI



BOOKED (Left) Dhaval Thakkar, the main accused in the Rajkot fire incident, after his arrest from Abu Road, Rajasthan; three other accused in court, May 27

A SOCIAL MEDIA POST FROM MARCH 2022 SHOWS RAJKOT'S TOP ADMINISTRATORS POSING WITH THE GAME ZONE'S OFFICIALS